

The Stranger

Almost two hours had passed since the last toll was taken. This is pretty standard routine; at about 02:00 Galactic Standard Time, the Spaceway is so empty it could fly off into the distant horizon with the slightest of solar winds. Stationed comfortably on the outer banks of the planet Scylla, the officer rests his arms out the window of his torn and tattered green toll booth. He stares out at the distant interstate of tightly woven cosmic debris (the remains of millenia-spanning planet collisions, tired asteroids, littered wrappers of Haloburgers from the less intelligent beings) and stardust, waiting patiently for a traveller to come through. Most of the traffic for the planet comes from the Spaceway's stop at Scheria, the "city of dreams"—it's the richest spot in the galaxy and it's all the way on the other side of the planet. Where the officer is stationed, the only reason to even consider dropping off the Spaceway is Ogygia, a lonesome little town once home to some of the brightest and most creative merchants the galaxy has ever seen. Ever since the corporation redrew the Spaceway's routes, the town became mostly abandoned, only home to a few stubborn Scyllans reminiscing over the old life. The officer doesn't mind; it makes his job easier.

Usually, the officer squirms in his dented leather chair, plays the latest Galacta Post word puzzle on his datapad, and tunes in to the after-hours Spacer's Sounds broadcast on the netlink. Unfortunately for the officer, he had finished the puzzle too early in his shift and the radio was currently playing a speciality showcase of some polarizing electronic punk releases that the officer cares little for. At the ripe hour of 03:00, he opts to take the time to stay at the window of the booth in silence, continuing to stare down the Spaceway.

It was then he saw something unusual.

Coming out of the void, a slender, dark silhouette appears in the distance, moving towards the officers booth. From here, the officer can't quite make out who it is or where they could possibly be coming from. What confuses the officer the most is the figure's lack of a ride—it is typically deemed impossible to travel the full extent of the Spaceway without a speeder or a ride from a shuttle ship.

The officer turned back into the booth to reach for his coffee. He needed to stay awake. The mug adorned large black letters: MOST EMPLOYEE. It was a corporate misprint. Turning back to the window, the officer drops the mug with a loud *crack* and howls in surprise upon seeing the mysterious figure staring straight at him a couple rocks away.

"Great stars! You move quick!" The officer said while examining the damage the coffee did to his work vest.

“Forgive me, it was not my intent to startle you. Are you alright?” The stranger spoke with a clear diction, unlike any tongue the officer had heard before. It sounded like a snake’s rattle, yet it rolled over the bumps in sound with ease.

“Yeah, this will come off just fine in the morning, no worries ‘bout that. I’m going to need to-”

The officer looks up from his shirt, finally seeing the stranger clearly under the dim orange spotlight hanging from the booth. The officer shakes his head, blinking fast. He could not believe what he was seeing. In all his years working the post, he had never before seen such a man. The stranger is tall, almost reaching the height of the window face-to-face. A long black cloak covers his body, obscuring any possible contraband the officer needs to check for. What was clear as day is his gray skin, chiseled and cracked like a sculptor’s passion project. The officer can’t quite make out if there is a full nose or pair of lips on the man. The strangest feature of them all is the long, wire antenna embedded deep into the base of his skull, flashing red periodically.

“Uh, what–what are you?”

“Oh, just a traveler,” the stranger states plainly.

“No, I–well, I’ve just never seen nobody like the likes of you before.”

The stranger gives a small grin. “Is that so?”

“That’s right. And I’ve worked here for quite some time.” The officer stands up straighter.

“Well, consider this a welcome surprise,” the stranger replies, dipping down to do a slight bow.

“We’ll see ‘bout that,” the officer mutters, skeptical of the stranger. “I assume you’re headed into town?”

“And you assume why?”

“Just a guess.” The officer chuckles at his own joke. “I ain’t see any other reason to come this way.”

“Hm. Interesting.” The stranger seems to be squinting his eyes, but it is difficult for the officer to tell what kind of face he is making. Too long of a silence lingers between the two as the officer waits for the stranger to continue, but nothing more is said.

“Welp, I’m going to need to see some sort of identification from you.” The officer slouches back down, resting his chin on his arms, fending off the boredom creeping up on him.

“Why might that be?”

“Corporate rules. Making sure there’s nobody coming through who shouldn’t be.”

“And who decides who should and shouldn’t be where they choose to be?”

“Sir, I ain’t the one who decides that. I just need to see your ID,” the officer sighs, holding onto what little is left of his patience.

“Are you where you desire to be?” The stranger tilts his head, stepping closer to the booth. With the movement came a bright glow of the stranger’s antenna, the red light sweeping out between the two of them with a slight hum. At this, the officer pushes his head up from his arms.

“What did you say?”

“I asked if you are where you desire to be.”

The officer sighs. “No, I heard you—whatever. Look, I’m the one asking the questions here. Can I see your ID, sir?”

“Why must I identify myself to you if you cannot identify yourself to me?”

“Because I work here and you don’t. Is that clear?” The officer felt his blood pressure rise.

“Hm. I’m not sure you know what’s clear.” The stranger’s antenna hums again, brighter than the last time.

“Are we going to have a problem here?”

“Don’t we all have problems to solve? Here, let me—” The stranger steps forward, moving closer to the booth. The officer, in response, reaches under his vest and pulls out his small blaster pistol—standard corporate issue— and points it directly at the stranger.

“Stay where you are.”

“Ah. Cops, as usual,” the stranger says disappointedly, holding his hands in the air. “I am not a threat. I have no weapons. Can you please let me continue?”

“I don’t know what the hell you are,” the officer sneers, gripping the pistol tight.

“Well, we both know you don’t have it in you to shoot, so please, lower your gun.”

The officer nervously laughs. “You think so?”

“I know so,” the stranger says, taking another step closer. “Now let me—”

“STOP!” The officer is now shaking.

“Please, this is not helpful for either of us. You have never shot this gun before. In fact, I’m sure you’ve never even used the electric gate or the emergency laser cutter locked up behind you.”

The officer wavers, lowering the gun. “What?”

The stranger’s antenna shines the brightest it’s ever been. The orange light overhead flickered.

“You’ve been working here for the last 15 years. You had graduated from the High Guard Academy, keen on becoming a part of the elite force in Scheria, but struggled to impress the recruiters. You could not handle a rifle well—it reminded you too much of your father—and, unfortunately, settled for any position within the corporation, taking post at this remote spot.”

“You don’t know anything–”

“You take the graveyard shift on purpose, correct? You have never admitted it aloud, but you prefer solitude. Sometimes, you sneak the occasional moment of drinking on the job, knowing they never check the cameras late in the night.”

The officer blinks hard, lowering the gun to his side. He squints his eyes, focusing on the light coming from the stranger’s antenna. “Can you–”

“Yes, I can see it clearly. It’s so heavy on your soul.”

The officer falls back into his chair, processing what’s happening.

“Your drinking became a big problem. You’d come home to your wife in the morning, restless, agitated, and aggressive. Eventually, she had enough, and after one final fight, she packed all her things and hopped on the nearest shuttle, headed for some far off planet. You couldn’t bear the pain, so you took on later and longer shifts, drinking more. Most of your credits are used on alcohol.” The stranger looked around. “I’d guess a lot of these wrappers come from you. You waste your days repeating the same routine each and every day, torn between despising the city of dreams and wishing you were a part of it. If only you could be up there: living behind pearly white walls, taking walks down the Aegean Park, seeing all of the bubbled trees and breathing in the fresh air, speaking with the rich about the news and how lovely the weather is. It is but a long forgotten dream of yours now, as you wait years and years for a promotion to reach you, wasting the time scrolling mindlessly on the netlink, watching travellers come in and out of the Spaceway.”

The officer hangs limp in the chair, utterly speechless. He has never seen such a trick like this before; no common spaceman has ever passed this booth with such abilities. The officer feels naked against the gaze of the stranger, feeling claustrophobic within the small space of his booth.

“That- that isn’t entirely true. You’re missing a couple details,” the officer retaliates. “What about my kid? What about the excellent coffee I brew?” The officer gives his best grin, but it’s a weak one.

“But I’m right, aren’t I?” The stranger stands just as tall as before.

The officer takes a moment to think.

“But what does it matter?” the officer says. “What good is there in thinking about it?”

“It might be better to face the facts before you repress it forever.”

There is another moment of silence between the two. The hum of the stranger’s antenna begins to die down while he stands in front of the officer. He waits, watching the officer, tapping his foot occasionally.

“Well, I best be going now. Do you mind?” The stranger gestures towards the direction of Ogygia, past the toll booth.

The officer absentmindedly nods, saying nothing of identification, contraband, or credits. He watches as the stranger comfortably walks beyond the booth, creeping down the Spaceway.

Before the stranger is just out of sight of the booth, the officer sees the stranger's antenna flicker inconsistently, whirling and humming. The stranger stops in his tracks, breaking out of his previously displayed coolness to appear agitated. He reaches up, yanks hard on the antenna, and with a distant *pop*, the officer watches as the antenna comes out of the stranger's head with ease. It was as if it had never once been connected to the stranger's skull.

"Ah, that's unfortunate," the stranger mutters, just loud enough for the officer to hear. "I suppose I'll buy a new one in town."

"WAIT!" The officer sticks his head far out of the window, shouting at the stranger. "I don't understand? Was that not—"

"Oh, this silly thing? It's quite an accessory, isn't it?" The stranger says with a smile.

"Wait—then how did you know so much about me?" the officer yells, his voice desperate and weak.

"Hm," the stranger strokes his chin. "Just a guess, I suppose?"